

Ruger .204 Part 2

I have to admit that since my introduction to the .204 Ruger cartridge my opinion of it has change greatly. When I was first introduced to it in an article that appeared in the American Rifleman I was less than impressed to say the least. It appeared to me that another wheel had been invented just to generate sales for the manufactures. After all we had the 220 Swift that could do 4,000 fps so why would we need a smaller cartridge by .02 calibers that's doing nearly the same thing.

In Part one I have out lined the load development that I conducted for this cartridge, and what I was experiencing in the field hunting woodchucks. Now at the time of this writing (2013) I have to admit that I've really become hooked on the .204 Ruger cartridge.



Seen here a top a hay bale is my custom Borden varmint rifle in .204 Ruger. Keeping it company is a chuck that fell to it's 39 grain Sierra Blitz King.

Looking back through the entries in my log of chuck hunting (since 2007) I find that I have been using my two rifles chambered for the 204 Ruger cartridge on more than 95% of my hunts. My Cooper M21 in 204 has log exactly 100 kills as of this spring, and my other 204 Ruger (a custom by Jim Borden) had a total of 109 kills. There are some 12 to 16 crows and pigeons included in those totals, but the majority are all woodchucks and one red fox.

While chuck hunting I like to post a watch over fields that appear to have a good population of chucks. I find it relaxing and it affords time to reflect on my thoughts somewhat un-interrupted. It was on a sunny warm day this spring that I found myself in such a position mulling over the self imposed question of "Why am I so hooked on the 204?" At first my thought wandered to the Cooper M21 rifle that I mentioned in Part one. That rifle is one of the best looking rifles I have ever owned. The tiger stripped walnut stock is

simply outstanding, and it's left handed. (I shoot long guns from the left side due to an eye problem in my right eye). The rifle is very accurate with the hand loads that I developed, and the trigger is one of the best that I have ever had in a factory rifle. These were good reasons to favor a rifle but I have other rifles that would fit in nearly the same category. So this was not the reason that I was so hooked on the 204 Ruger.

Then there is my other rifle in 204 Ruger. This rifle was built on a Borden stainless steel Alpine single shot bolt action. It has a fine Jewel trigger and a Krieger barrel 26" long with Remington varmint master contour. Stocked with an HS Precision stock that is nearly the same as a Remington 700 Varmint Master it is mounted with a Night force 8-32X power scope. The chamber of this rifle was cut with a set of Pacific Tool & Die reamers to my specs having zero free bore. Just shy of having a benchrest stock it was as accurate a testing platform as could be made to test both from bench and in the field. These are all great reasons also to favor a rifle but it still didn't answer my question of why I was so hooked on the 204 Ruger cartridge.

My mulling over these thoughts was interrupted by movement in the distance. A tiny reddish brown dot in the green field below me had caught my eye. Peering through the rifles scope the object spotted was a chuck stuffing his face with clover. Most of his body was hidden by the clover that he was so intently ingesting, but there was enough of him exposed to get a shot on. The laser range finder gave a reading of 269 yards, so one MOA was added to the elevation knob over the 200 yard *BASE ZERO* and the shot taken.

My view through the rifle scope was spectacular. It seemed nearly instantaneous that the bullet had found it's mark. The chuck's body swelled and a puff of dust and red mist erupted as the chuck fell motionless. While reloading the rifle my thoughts again turned to my question. It was then that an answer started to emerge. First of all the recoil of the 204 was mild enough that I didn't lose the sight picture when the shot was fired. I got to watch the hit and was not punished by recoil or severity of muzzle blast. There was also the flatness of the bullets trajectory. The trajectory of the 204 Ruger when sighted for a 200 yard *BASE ZERO* in very flat shooting. At 100 yards it's only about 5/8" high, and at 300 yards it is only 3 3/4 " low. Not quite a laser beam but very flat as rifle trajectories go. It's easy to understand that when shooting at such distance as mentioned precision elevation setting are necessary when the targeted area of impact may be as little as 1 1/2" in height. A standing chuck doesn't present the hunter with this problem, but a chuck that is peeking from it's den or obscured by tall grass can and will. So a flat trajectory is a big plus to the chuck hunter.



I shot this old male chuck was shot at 176 yards while peeking from it's den in tall clover. All that was showing was the top of his head and an eye that was keeping watch on me. His false sense of security proved to be his demise when the Borden 204 Ruger delivered a Sierra Blitz King bullet to his forehead. For those of you that are not chuck hunters I have included this photo to give you an idea of the size that can be attained by a well fed adult chuck. This one measure from the tip of his nose to the base of it's tail 22" long and 10" across the shoulders. It is been proven in agricultural studies that a single adult chuck will consume up to 1,500 pounds of clover in one season. Keep in mind that any fruit or vegetables are also on the chucks menu.

I have noticed that over the past 30 some years the places where a chuck hunter can shoot over 500 yards are fast disappearing. More and more rural areas are having homes spring up in what used to be prime chuck hunting county. The distances that we are now shooting are much shorter today than they were years ago. Most shots are now days between 125 and 300 yards. Occasionally there are longer shots but that is not the rule. Also a rifle that has a mild report excites the locals and their live stock a bunch less, another plus to getting invited back to hunt an area again. The report of a 204 Ruger is a sharp crack, and not like the thunderous boom of an F15 breaking the sound barrier.

My Hunting companions and I have pushed the 204 Ruger to what we feel is their useful limit in distance while chuck hunting. Mind you this is not computer generated theory but rather what we have learned firsthand in the field. To date my longest kill shot on a chuck with the 204 Ruger using a Sierra 39 grain Blitz King bullet at a muzzle velocity of 3949 fps (chronograph measured 10 feet in front of the muzzle) has been 504 yards (laser measured distance). I'm sure that there are some hunters who have on occasion exceed that distance with the .204 Ruger, but I would highly recommend that shots on chuck size game be kept to around 400 yards max. Keep in mind that the .204 is a tiny bullet and that wind will kick it around a bunch if you are not careful reading the conditions. That said I must also stress that the main force in a 204s killing power lies in it's velocity and the shock wave it produces on impact.

Although spectacular on varmints the 204 Ruger should be limited to hunting coyote size critters and smaller. I've have been told of white tailed deer being harvested with the 204 Ruger. I'm sure that it will kill a deer but strongly do not recommend it's use in such sport. The 204's bullet is small and at the speed reached in the 204 Ruger it is explosive on contact. It will not penetrate deep on mussel or through thick bone. Used on big game it will surly produce more wounded animals that not.

Feeling somewhat satisfied with answering my question I know that I will continue to use the .204 Ruger for much of my mid range chuck hunting. I'm very well pleased with the 204 Ruger cartridge in the role that I have used it. It does fill a gap in the lineup of cartridges used in varmint hunting very well. I'm sure it will be with us for a long time to come.

A few words of caution to those of you who my want to try a rifle in .204 Ruger. Be advised that at the advent of this cartridge the original chamber had a short free bore and those rifle shoot very accurate. However as the first few years of production progressed the throat, or free bore, of the chamber was lengthen. In most rifles produced today the throat has excessive free bore and it is near impossible to seat a bullet to land contact. To complicate things in this matter enter the fact that some manufactures chamber AR 15 type rifles to the .204 Ruger. In doing so the 204 Ruger cartridge has be held to and over all loaded length that will fit in the AR magazine. To do this factory loaded ammo is loaded with the bullet seated very deep in the case. This sets the bullet even farther back from land contact. A rifle with a long free bore and using bullets seated far from land contact where it has to travel in the free bore some time as much as .300" to land contact is not conducive to best accuracy. Don't think this is so, talk to any Benchrest Shooter and as him about this. I'm sure you'll get and ear full.

May all your shot find their intended mark, John Del Savio